

## Cohort Project Charge for PrivaPal Kid's Privacy Game

*\*Completion of this form is required in order to submit a cohort project proposal.*

- *Effort is limited to*
  - *6 hours per week per intern, or*
  - *300 hours total for the summer (assumes 5 interns)*
- *What to expect from interns:*
  - *No prior experience working at U-M*
  - *Expect all interns to have no professional experience prior to the internship*

### Executive Summary

- Summer internship will advance PrivaPals, an educational video-game designed to teach children ages 9 to 11 about digital privacy and surveillance, aspirationally, with a goal towards creating a beta version with aspirations for a multi-scenario educational product, with all work documented to ensure continuity beyond the internship period. The interns will continue work initiated and developed by student temps based on a class project, and will work in conjunction with these students on the project.

### About the Project

#### **Project Sponsor(s) and Sponsoring Department(s):**

- Sol Bermann, Exec. Dir Privacy & Faculty Affairs; Privacy Office
- Svetla Sytch, Assistant Director of Privacy and IT Policy
- A cohort of Privacy Office student workers that began the work, and will be providing direction, support and knowledge transfer

**Cohort Project Manager:** [TBD, This will be the Intern Serving as the Project Manager]

**Requested Start Date:** May 15, 2026

**Target End Date:** August 1, 2026

### Project Details

#### **Problem Statement**

Children ages 9 to 11 are among the most surveilled demographics on the internet, yet few resources meaningfully prepare them to navigate that reality. While Federal law restricts how platforms collect children's data, it does not teach children how to protect themselves, and most existing privacy education tools have failed to close that gap. Our review of eight leading digital privacy education games found that current options either engage children without teaching them anything substantive, or teach correctly but fail to hold attention. Educational research over the past 10 years confirms that privacy education tends to focus on what not to do rather than helping children understand context-specific harms and how to address them. PrivaPals was designed to address what existing tools do not. When designed thoughtfully, games can remove barriers to educational access and build genuine competency rather than teaching children surface-level, rule-following tasks. PrivaPals teaches children not just what the rules are, but why privacy matters, who collects their data, and what they can actually do to protect themselves in our increasingly interconnected worlds that span both in-person and online.

## Project Benefits and Goals

How will we know that the project benefits were achieved?

We hope to have enough of the game developed to show

- Completed scenarios that articulate, in post-play reflection, at least two ways that apps or platforms collect data without explicit consent, as well as strategies they can take to limit data collection and protect their personal information from individual or corporate actors.
- In-game consequences produce measurable differences in player awareness scores between players who engaged carelessly versus those who made privacy-conscious choices.
- All with a goal for children ages 9 to 13 to be able to navigate scenarios without adult assistance.

## What is this project expected to accomplish

- *Product:* At least one complete game scenario is fully playable, internally tested, and stable by end of summer. A second scenario is scoped, designed, and partially implemented such that it can be completed by a future contributor without significant rework.
- *Continuity:* All work — code, design decisions, research instruments, and open questions — is committed to the GitHub repository with documentation sufficient for any future intern or ITS team member to continue without direct knowledge transfer.
- *Research:* A usability testing protocol is drafted with an eventual goal of a designed, IRB-ready proposal, including a research findings template and recruitment plan produced so testing can proceed in the future.

The summer internship will advance PrivaPals from design stage to at least one fully playable scenario. Specific deliverables include: a fully implemented Scenario 3 focused on behavioral tracking and algorithmic profiling, a cross-scenario data visualization layer that makes invisible tracking systems visible to players, a structured usability testing report with children ages 9–13, and a prioritized Year 2 roadmap for platform expansion and public release.

## Skills Needed (What kinds of work will interns do?)

- Interns will work primarily in front-end web technologies — HTML, CSS, and JavaScript — to build and iterate on browser-based game scenarios. Core tasks include implementing interactive gameplay loops, designing animated UI feedback systems, and maintaining a clean, readable codebase.
- Familiarity with vibe coding workflows (using AI-assisted development tools to accelerate prototyping) is a plus, as the project moves quickly from concept to working prototype.
- UX sensibility matters: the game must feel intuitive with no tutorial required.
- Experience with animation, transitions, and interactive visual design is helpful, as the surveillance mechanics layer relies heavily on making invisible data systems *visible* through motion and feedback.

## What known challenges and concerns does this effort face?

- What problems are known that could impact the project's success?

The primary challenge is scope management, as the game has ambitious design goals and a history of expanding beyond what a small team can deliver in a single engagement. Clear milestone checkpoints and a strict pilot-first mentality are the main guardrails.

Single-contributor risk is significant. With one intern driving development, design, and research simultaneously, any extended absence stalls all workstreams at once. Consistent GitHub documentation and weekly commit habits are the mitigation.

Finally, ITS hosting constraints are not yet fully known. The game is built to run as a zero-dependency browser experience, but deploying on University of Michigan infrastructure may surface restrictions around external libraries, security headers, or JavaScript execution that require rework close to launch.

### **Project History**

- Is there any existing documentation or resources regarding this effort that could be helpful to the project team?
  - Yes. The current student team has created a shared Google folder, and will continue to work with the interns on this project.
- Has this project been started, but not completed, in the past?
  - No. This originally began as an undergrad class project, and was essentially an “idea” that is now being ideated and iterated through to become an actual app/game
- Has ITS been involved in past versions of this project?
  - No, not exactly, but the Privacy Office frequently works to create education and engagement activities and courses

### **How Will Decisions Be Made?**

- Who is responsible for reviewing and approving all changes to the project?
  - Sol Bermann, Svetla Sytch, in consultation with the student workers that started the project

### **End of Summer Transition**

- Sol Bermann, Svetla Sytch
- We will consider whether we can engage additional students to carry on the project (including hiring former ITS interns), assess whether regular staff can continue the work, and even explore outsourcing continued development